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Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S)

JOKING AND PRIVILEGED FAMILIARITY • Utani: **Joking**, Sexual License and Social Obligations Among the Luguru

The Luguru are a Bantu tribe numbering approximately 200,000 living in the Uluguru Mountains and adjacent plains in East-central Tanganyika. They follow the hoe-type of agriculture, most of them living barely above the subsistence level. While the population is fairly dense in some areas, there are few villages, as the people tend to live in dispersed hamlets consisting of a few huts of the cone-cylinder type of construction.

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The key to the social structure is the matrilineal clan, and “clan” is used here to describe an exogamous local grouping, members of which own land in common and manifest a high degree of collective responsibility.³ Clan members believe they are related by descent from sisters who were among the first migrants of the clan to the Uluguru area. Each clan is headed by a senior elder who should belong to the particular lineage within the clan known in Luguru as *tombo dukuru*, or the “big breast.” This segment of the clan is said to be descended from the eldest sister of the original migrants. The senior elder is assisted by a council of elders, some of whom control the affairs of their particular lineage within the clan.

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Succession and inheritance ideally goes to the sister's son, and the avunculate obtains among the Luguru. While there is a tendency today to place an increasing emphasis on patrilineal descent and control, in former times under the avunculate the authority of a Luguru over his sister's children existed to a degree where he could dispose of them as slaves without the consent of the father. Residence is traditionally matrilineal and accompanied by mother-in-law avoidance. There are no traditional chiefs in the usual sense of the term, and no political integration beyond the clan was recognized prior to domination of the area by the Arabs and Europeans.

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Every Luguru clan claims to have a utani relationship, involving joking and obligations, with one or more clans in their vicinity. While utani is a Swahili term rather than Luguru,⁴ it is being used here instead of the Luguru

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equivalent, *ugongo*, as this is the practice followed by the Luguru themselves. Actually, the term *utani* is not commonly used, but rather the plural and singular, *watani* and *mtani*. According to the Luguru, the *utani* relationship between clans developed as a result of warfare during the initial occupancy of Uluguru. An immigrant group would defeat, or be defeated by, a group already residing there, but the victors would permit the losers to remain and become *watani*. A less violent origin was reported for cases where immigrants would be given land to cultivate without fighting, and it was also stated that considerable intermarriage between two clans over a long period could result in their becoming *watani*.

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JOKING AND PRIVILEGED FAMILIARITY

The greatest degree of **joking** is carried on between *watani* of the same generation, and cross-sexual **joking** is common, with obscene and suggestive  1316 language and horseplay. What might otherwise be regarded as common assault becomes good clean fun between *watani*. For example, a man may **jokingly** grab a woman's cloth and attempt to disrobe her, and a good-natured tug-of-war or wrestling may result. A woman may deride a *mtani* about his lack of sexual prowess, and imply that he is sterile or impotent. He may respond with an invitation to accompany him in order to demonstrate his virility. The fact that a man is married does not prohibit him from indulging in a jesting conversation with sexual overtones, particularly with unmarried *watani*. However, it is considered bad form for a man to make suggestive or obscene remarks to a married *mtani* of the opposite sex unless her husband is present.

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³ There are several clans bearing the same name throughout the Luguru area and contiguous tribes, resulting from fission of groups during and after migration to Uluguru. In their discussion of the Luguru, Young and Fosbrooke refer to all groups bearing the same name as a maximal lineage or clan, with a major lineage defining the largest corporate group with proprietary rights to a particular area of land (1960:45ff). It is the major lineage that is used here to mean "clan," as this is the largest group that observes collective responsibility, owns land in common, acknowledges the leadership of a senior elder and shares the bridewealth or divides funeral expenses.

While all clans bearing the same name believe themselves to be somehow related and would not intermarry, the *utani* relationship of one clan would not be binding on, or recognized by, other clans by the same name comprising what has been described as the maximal lineage. Each develops its own *utani* relationship with contiguous clans.

Young and Fosbrooke note the presence of *utani* among the Luguru, but state that all clans do not have such a relationship (1960:44). However, the writer did not encounter or hear about a clan that did not claim to be *watani* with some other clan, and Luguru informants could not imagine a clan not having *watani*.

⁴ If the usual Bantu prefixes of the area were used, the tribe or the plural would be *Waluguru*, singular *Mluguru*, the area they occupy *Uluguru*, and the languages *Kiluguru* or *Kiswahili*. Unless otherwise indicated, Swahili terminology is used in this paper.

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